

HAUNTED BY THE PAST

TEXT: Exodus 20:1-6 *“And God spoke all these words: 2 “I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery. 3 “You shall have no other gods before me. 4 “You shall not make for yourself an image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below. 5 You shall not bow down to them or worship them; for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me, 6 but showing love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments.”*

INTRO: Our October series is **“HAUNTED.”** Please know, we are in no way attempting to celebrate Halloween, the devil’s day! We are

going to attempt to teach you, that you have nothing to fear from your past, present, or future, if you are a child of God! We are going to take Halloween away from the devil and his crowd this year, by seeing dozens of people set free from the grip of Satan!

Haunt (Dictionary.com):

(1) To visit habitually or appear to frequently, as a spirit or ghost. (2) To recur persistently to the consciousness of. (3) To visit frequently or go to often.

My personal definition of haunted is, “*To be troubled by something to the point of allowing it to influence your decisions about your present and future.*” This definition is what I am referring to as we preach our way through the month of October.

I. HAUNTED BY THE SINS OF ANCESTORS

Many people do not believe in generational curses. It doesn't take a very smart person to see that there are certain medical issues, personal habits, sins and weakness that seem to follow family lines.

Go to a Doctor for the first time and see how long it takes you to fill out the paperwork! Almost every question either has to do with your ancestry or your previous medical issues.

Here is what our text say's on the subject... ***“I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me.”*** Notice here, the sins of the father are visited upon the children to the third and fourth generation! How is this possible?

This word is explicitly to “...*those who hate me.*” Most people would not own up to hating the Lord. So, who are those who hate the Lord?

- Those who do not follow the Lord...
- Those who ignore the commandments of the Lord...
- Those who choose to walk in their own way, rather than in the way of the Lord...
- Those who despise (Do not properly value) the Lord, His word and His Church...

The sins of these people continue their unbroken chain of devastation in the family line because there is no action taken to stop it. Sin is a learned behavior! When sinful behavior is learned and not changed the consequences also remain the same! The definition of insanity is to keep doing things the same way while expecting different results!

Think of the example of the Children of Israel:

- They lived in slavery for 400 years...
- The slave mentality passed to their children and because of that, the next generation could not go into Canaan...
- Moses and Joshua broke the vicious cycle of doubt and unbelief (It took them 40 years to do it), so that the grandchildren actually inherited the Promised Land...
- Once Joshua took them into Canaan it was 150 years before anyone actually saw a giant... The giants are what kept them out and they didn't even see one for 150 years!

If in our generation and on our watch, we want to break the grip Satan has had on our family line, the only way we can do it is through the power of God!

Look at this... The sins of the parents can pass to the third and fourth generation (My Great-Great-Grandchildren). Please know that none of us are being charged for the sins of anyone else, the issue is that because of the sins of those who came before us, we learned bad habits and behaviors that if not broken, will have a negative effect on our lives, and an even worse effect on our children... Grandchildren... And great-grandchildren...

I have a word, in fact, I have two words for someone this morning... STOP IT!!! STOP THE CURSE IN YOUR GENERATION!!!

Haunted by personal failures

Remember my definition of haunted? *“To be troubled by something to the point of allowing it to influence your decisions about your present and future.”*

This we know, God forgives and forgets! That is God who forgets:

- Your wife or husband may not forget but God does...
- Your children may not forget but God does...
- Your friends-n-them may not forget but God does...
- Your mother-in-law may not forget but God does...

We can talk all day about who doesn't forget our past and continually holds us responsible for it, but the truth is that we have a harder time forgetting our past sins and failures, than does anyone else! When the devil got kicked out of Heaven this is what is recorded about that turn of events... Revelation 12:10-11 ***"The accuser of our brethren is cast down, which accused them before our God day and night.*** ¹¹ ***And they***

overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony; and they loved not their lives unto the death.”

- He accuses man to God... (He keeps bringing our past up to God – To no avail because God forgives and forgets)
- He accuses God to man... (He attempts to convince us that God doesn't love us... Care about us... Deliver us... Heal us... etc...)
- He accuses us to ourselves... (Here is where he does the most damage... Self-loathing etc...)

Are we going to live in the haunting of the past or are we going to cast off the restraints of the past and step into the glorious future that God has planned for us?

Moving from generational curses to generational blessings

According to our text, the sins of the father are visited upon the children to the third and fourth generation, (Great-great-grandchildren) but listen to this... ***“I the Lord will... Show love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments.”*** (That is Grandchildren with 998 Greats in front of it...)

When a generational curse is broken and a generational blessing is established, each generation is more powerful, prosperous and blessed than the last generation...

- Elijah – Elisha... (Double portion anointing – Gehazi could had a 4-times-anointing but he surrendered it)
- David – Solomon... (David was a peasant servant boy, who became a king – Solomon was far more powerful and prosperous than his father)

- Obed Edom... (63 descendants that served in the house of the Lord)
- Jesus and His followers... (You will do greater things)

CONCLUSION:

Renowned Pentecostal theologian, Stanley Horton said, *"Does a Christian need to do something about breaking a generational curse? The word hate in the Hebrew is a participle indicating characteristic or continuous action. Thus, the children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren who keep on hating God reap a cumulative effect of God's judgment. On the other hand, those who turn from hatred of God and choose to love Him reap something far greater. They become part of a line that reaps the benefits of God's love on a thousand generations of godly people who preceded them. Thus, those loving God will not suffer any*

judgment or curse from what their parents or ancestors did” and I would like to add, “In the same way that the sins of generations are cumulative, the blessings of generations are cumulative! The cumulative blessing has a snowball effect!”

We must decide right here and now, whether we are going to pass on the haunting of our past or initiate a new era of generational blessing, that will continue for a thousand generations if necessary!

II. HAUNTED BY POOR DECISIONS

Exodus 20:1-6 *“And God spoke all these words: 2 “I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery. 3 “You shall have no other gods before me. 4 “You shall not make for yourself an image in the form of anything in heaven above*

*or on the earth beneath or in the waters below.
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them; for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous
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Last week: (Sins continue in a family line of those who hate God, to the third and fourth generation – Blessings are upon those who love God for a Thousand generations)

- End generational curses...
- Begin the process of generational blessing...
- Continue generational blessing...

My personal definition for *haunted* is “*To be troubled by something to the point of allowing it*

to influence our decisions about our present and future.”

All of us have known the pain and disappointment of making decisions that have turned out to be, well, less than brilliant!

Haven't we? Any 100%'ers in here?

In considering how poor decisions can haunt us I cannot help but think of one of the Bible's most prolific characters – Moses!

The history (His-story) of Moses:

- God called Abraham to follow Him and He became the father of the Jewish race...
- The descendants of Abraham ended up in Egypt, and after a time became enslaved for four hundred years...
- In a state of paranoia, Pharaoh ordered all male, Hebrew babies, two years and under, to be killed...

- Moses was born during the time that Pharaoh was executing children...
- Moses' parents accomplish a fete that is near unto impossible – They hid their newborn baby three months...
- When she could no longer hide her child, the mother of Moses placed him in a basket on the Nile river where Pharaoh's daughter was known to bathe...
- Moses was adopted by Pharaoh's daughter and raised as Pharaoh's grandson (With all the privileges that go with it)...
- Moses birth mother (Jocabed) was hired to be Moses' nanny... (Not bad – Get paid to raise your own children – Isn't that just like the Lord)
- No doubt Jocabed (His real mother) instilled in his little heart that he was a Hebrew, not an Egyptian...

- As Moses grew into manhood, he became unsettled by the suffering of the Israelis...
- At the age of forty, in a moment of seething anger, Moses killed an Egyptian for mistreating an Israelite...
- Because of this uncharacteristically bad decision, Moses was forced to flee as a wanted man... (One decision defined the life of Moses for the next forty years – How long have you been haunted by a poor decision?)
- Moses fled to the desert of Midian where he tended sheep for the next forty years... (From age 40 to age 80! How many bad days do you think Moses had over this 40-year stretch? He could have been living in a palace but he was camped out on a hill in Midian watching sheep! Talk about tough breaks...)

Just because Moses made a bad decision doesn't automatically follow that his entire life had to be defined by a poor decision! The same is true for all of us! How long are we going to wallow in the defeat of a poor decision? How long are we going to allow the haunting to continue?

At the age of eighty GOD made a trip to the desert of Midian, to visit a fugitive from justice, and look at what occurs there! Exodus 3:1-6

“Now Moses was tending the flock of Jethro his father-in-law, the priest of Midian, and he led the flock to the far side of the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God. 2 There the angel of the Lord appeared to him in flames of fire from within a bush. Moses saw that though the bush was on fire it did not burn up. 3 So Moses thought, “I will go over and see this strange sight—why the bush does not burn up.” 4 When the Lord saw that he had gone over to look, God called to him from

within the bush, “Moses! Moses!” And Moses said, “Here I am.” 5 “Do not come any closer,” God said. “Take off your sandals, for the place where you are standing is holy ground.” 6 Then he said, “I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob.” At this Moses hid his face because he was afraid to look at God.”

Really? God is really talking to a murderer about becoming a deliverer?

Just because you have a record is no indication that God can't use you! The reason some of us don't have a record is we were too frightened to do what we really wanted to - Or we didn't get caught!

Jehovah is a God of turnaround! Just as He turned Moses haunting into an opportunity, He is about to end the haunting of some folks in this

room today and turn your captivity into creativity!

When Moses was 40, he had the right motive (concern for his people) but made a poor decision and that one decision haunted him for the next forty years!

After forty years of exile, reflecting on what might have been, Moses meets up with God at the burning bush. What happens when a failure meets the manifest presence of God?

- Someone gets a turnaround!
- Someone receives a “*Get out of jail free*” card!
- Someone finds out what deliverance really feels like!
- Someone gets reassigned from the desert of Midian to a Kingdom assignment!

- Someone gets set free and everyone around them gets to experience an Exodus!

Some would say that Moses was disqualified by a mistake, but they forgot to inform Jehovah of the list of qualifications for Israel's deliverer!

You may have written yourself off, or others may have deemed you unqualified because of a poor decision. It may be true that almost everyone in your life may agree, but I am here today to tell you the bush is on fire again and God is saying, *"I have a turnaround assignment tailor made for you."* ***"The gifts and callings of God are irrevocable."***

(ILLUSTRATION: THE PAST HAS NO ARMS – MANY PEOPLE BELIEVE THEY ARE BEING HELD HOSTAGE BY THE PAST – THE TRUTH IS – WE ARE HOLDING ONTO OUR PAST)

Think of this:

- Moses poor decision led him into a wilderness season for forty years...
- His poor decision strategically positioned him in a place where he could hear from God... (The bush was in Midian – Not Egypt's palace! Sometimes God has to allow us to be shut out, so He can shut us in!)
- God used Moses mistake to give him forty years of experience, surviving in the desert, before He allowed Moses to lead the Israelites for forty years in the desert... (If Moses had stayed in the Palace he would not have been prepared for the desert! Here is a great truth for someone today – God has you right where He wants you – He is about to end the haunting today and begin the Hallelujah chorus!)
- He entered the desert a 40-year-old man, full of training, education, promise and passion...

- He exited the desert an 80-year-old man, full of temperance, wisdom, humility and survival skills...

CONCLUSION:

The thing about poor decisions is that Satan intends to trouble (Haunt) us with those decisions to the point that they negatively influence the decisions of our present and future!

If we will allow the Lord to do so, He will
“Take what the devil meant for evil and use it for our good and His glory!”

Moses had the training of the palace but now he had the experience of the desert! This uniquely qualified Moses to be the very deliverer God needed to set His people free!

By the time God was finished with Moses the devil was wishing he had never picked the fight!

What are you going to do with the poor decisions you have been haunted by? Are you going to continue to wallow in a pit of self-loathing or are you going to pick yourself up and allow God to use you to destroy what the enemy tried to create?

The devil ran Moses out of Egypt with the haunting of a poor decision – Moses training in the desert of Midian made him the perfect deliverer to set free 2 ½ or 3 million Israelites!

There would be no Moses story, without Moses' mistake. There would be no Moses story without the desert of Midian.

Please do not let the mistakes of yesterday to keep you from allowing God to redeem today and all of your tomorrows, for you!

III. HAUNTED BY FEAR

Exodus 20:1-6 *“And God spoke all these words: 2 “I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery. 3 “You shall have no other gods before me. 4 “You shall not make for yourself an image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below. 5 You shall not bow down to them or worship them; for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me, 6 but showing love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments.”*

Previous weeks:

- Haunted by generational curses...
- Haunted by poor decisions...
- Haunted families...

Today we are going to talk about being haunted by fear. My personal definition for *haunted* is “*To be troubled by something to the point of allowing it to influence our decisions about our present and future.*”

The Apostle Paul referred to fear in this way, “*the spirit of fear*”. This is a very interesting statement indeed. Fear is a spirit?

Two very important facts about fear:

- Fear as an emotion... (Someone scaring you
- Frightened by a sudden circumstance -
Fear as an emotion is a good thing)
- Fear as a spirit... (Constant ongoing fear with regard to a thing - Affects Christians and non-Christians alike)

Being haunted by a spirit of fear is paralyzing. Some of you have rolled up in here afraid of your own shadow. You are paralyzed by a spirit

of fear. Somebody is going to get set free in here today!

Fear is referred to as a specific spirit, “*The spirit of fear.*” At one time or another we have all been the target and victim of the spirit of fear.

Wikipedia say’s, phobias are irrational fears of things and situations which can be a danger, but most are not harmful.

Here is a partial listing of such fears:

- Ablutophobia (Ab-blue-toe-phobia) - Fear of bathing, washing, or cleaning
- Achluophobia (Uh-clue-o-phobia) – Fear of darkness
- Acrophobia (Ack-ro-phobia) – Fear of heights
- Agyrophobia (A-guy-ro-phobia) – Fear of crossing the road – (Why did the Razorbacks cross the road? Because they couldn’t get across the goal line)

- Bananaphobia – Fear of bananas (Those mean old bananas)
- Belomophobia (Belo-mo-o-phobia) – Fear of needles
- Bibliophobia – Fear of books (I was bound by this through Junior high and high school)
- Cacophobia (Kack-o-phobia) - Fear of ugliness (Ladies, look at your husband – Say it with me. *“I’m obviously not bound by cacophobia”*)
- Catoptrophobia (ku-top-tro-phobia)– Fear of mirrors (A lot of people seem to struggle with this... Otherwise why would they go out in public looking like they do?)
- Chionophobia (Chi-on-o-phobia) – Fear of snow
- Decidophobia (Decid-o-phobia) – Fear of making a decision – (I am crippled by this LOL)
- Demophobia (Demo-phobia) – Fear of crowds (If you struggle with this just attend life group or prayer meeting)

- Dendrophobia (Den-dro-phobia) – Fear of trees (I struggled with this growing up! Switches grow on trees)
- Dentophobia (Den-tro-phobia) – Fear of dentists
- Geliophobia (Gel-ee-o-phobia) – Fear of laughter (If you are happy, notify your face!)
- Gymnophobia (Gym-no-phobia) – Fear of nudity (This fear is just about extinct in this culture - I have a friend who pastors a church that is located right next to a nudist colony – At least he has an excuse for how his crowd looks!)
- Islamophobia (Islam-o- phobia) – Fear of Muslims (American Indian – Muslim – Cowboy – American Indian said “*Once we were many, now we are few*” – The Muslim said, “*Once we were few, now we are many*” – The Cowboy said, “*That is because we haven’t played cowboys and muslims yet.*”)

- Indophobia (Indo-phobia) - Fear of Indians (Elizabeth Warren is obviously not struggling with this)
- Nomophobia (No-mo-phobia) – Fear of losing contact with a mobile phone (Feel in my pockets for my phone – Phantom rings)
- Octophobia (Octo-phobia) – Fear of the number eight (That mean old number eight!)
- Ornithophobia (Or-neat-o-phobia) – Fear of birds
- Pediophobia (Ped-ee-o-phobia) – Fear of children (You are right to be afraid of some children)
- Phengophobia (Fing-o-phobia) – Fear of daylight
- Philophobia (Fee-lo-phobia) – Fear of love
- Pyrophobia (Pie-ro-phobia) – Fear of fire (I know some pastors and churches that are bound by this)
- Taphophobia (Taff-o-phobia) – Fear of grave and/or being buried alive (Ever been

buried alive? If not, how do you know to be afraid of it?)

- Zoophobia – Fear of animals

All this is funny unless you are bound by one of these things and then it is serious business. I am speaking prophetically right now, God is going to set the captives free this morning!

The fact that fear is a spirit sounds spooky and daunting but the fact is that Jesus said in Matthew 28:18 (KJV) ***“And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.”***

How much power did He say? All power!

Power:

- Over Heaven...
- Over Earth...
- Over man...
- Over animals...

- Over angels...
- Over demons...
- Over the devil...
- Over all spirits...

Now watch this... Luke 10:19 (KJV) “***Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy: and nothing shall by any means hurt you.***”

Jesus is saying that He has given the dominion that He conquered at Calvary to His people! Not just to the preachers but to every Child of God!

Our struggle is whether we have the same authority to debunk fear and rule over these things in our work-a-day life? Because of this we open the door to the spirit of fear.

He has raised us from our sinful condition and made us to SIT TOGETHER in Heavenly places in Christ Jesus. This means he has put us over:

- Principalities...
- Powers...
- Might...
- Dominion...
- Every named power, temporal and eternal...

How do we conquer a spirit of fear? With faith! Hebrews 11:1 (KJV) “*Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.*” Hebrews 11:1 (AMP) “*Now faith is the assurance (the confirmation, the title deed) of the things we hope for, being the proof of things we do not see and the conviction of their reality faith perceiving as real fact what is not revealed to the senses.*”

God is not moved by, nor does He respond to fear or desperation He responds to faith! Just like light and darkness cannot coexist, fear and faith cannot coexist! It is time for us to conquer

fear and walk by faith! Somebody is going to get a faith lift today!

Faith carries with it the ability to move what we need, from the Heavenly realm to the natural realm. ***“Life and death is in the power of the tongue.”*** (O be careful little mouth what you say)

Paul Tournier in his book *The Strong And The Weak* say's, *“All of us have reservoirs of full potential, vast areas of great satisfaction. But the roads that lead to those reservoirs are guarded by the dragon of fear.”*

Our problem is not believing God can, it is believing god will! Here is a life changing truth... He is more willing than able!

Faith goes beyond saying that God is able to believing and saying, *“He will do THIS...”*

CONCLUSION:

Here is what faith should look like in our lives:

- When confronted with difficulty, we refuse to say, “*It is impossible.*” We choose to confess... Luke 18:27 (NLT) “***What is impossible from a human perspective is possible with God.***”
- When we are weary, we refuse to say, “*I am too tired to go on.*” We choose to confess... Matthew 11:28-30 (NLT) “***Come to me, all of you who are weary and carry heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. ²⁹ Take my yoke upon you. Let me teach you, because I am humble and gentle, and you will find rest for your souls. ³⁰ For my yoke fits perfectly, and the burden I give you is light.***”
- When we have been betrayed in a relationship, we refuse to say, “*Nobody really loves or cares about me. I must not be good enough.*” We choose to confess... John 3:16 (NLT) “***For God so loved the world that he gave his only Son, so that***

everyone who believes in him will not perish but have eternal life.”

- When we have exhausted our resources, we refuse to say, *“I can’t go on.”* We choose to confess... 2 Corinthians 12:9 (NLT) ***“My gracious favor is all you need. My power works best in your weakness.”*** Psalms 91:15 (NLT) ***“When they call on me, I will answer; I will be with them in trouble. I will rescue them and honor them.”***
- When we do not know which way to turn, we refuse to say, *“What should I do?”* We choose to confess... Proverbs 3:5-6 (NLT) ***“Trust in the LORD with all your heart; do not depend on your own understanding. ⁶ Seek his will in all you do, and he will direct your paths.”***
- When we become weary with doing the right thing, we refuse to say, *“It’s not worth it.”* We choose to confess... Galatians 6:9 (NLT) ***“Don’t get tired of doing what is good. Don’t get discouraged and give up,***

for we will reap a harvest of blessing at the appropriate time.”

- When we have failed, we refuse to say, “*I can’t forgive myself.*” We choose to confess... 1 John 1:9 (NLT) “*If we confess our sins to him, he is faithful and just to forgive us and to cleanse us from every wrong.*” Romans 8:1 (NLT) “*There is no condemnation for those who belong to Christ Jesus.*”
- When we face financial hardships, we refuse to say, “*I can’t see a way out.*” We choose to confess... Philippians 4:19 (NLT) “*God will supply all your needs from his glorious riches, which have been given to us in Christ Jesus.*”
- When fear presses in on us, we refuse to say, “*I am afraid of what the future holds.*” We choose to confess... 2 Timothy 1:7 (NLT) “*God has not given us a spirit of fear and timidity, but of power, love, and self-discipline.*”

- When we face situations that are much bigger than we are, we refuse to say, “*I am not wise enough to negotiate this mess.*” We choose to confess... James 1:5 (NLT) “*If you need wisdom—if you want to know what God wants you to do—ask him, and he will gladly tell you. He will not resent your asking.*”

God’s will for everyone in this place is to move us from being haunted by fear to living and walking by faith! I ask each of you, are you ready to put an end to the haunting fear that has paralyzed you and step out on faith and believe God for the unthinkable?